Kent Date Enough

Human Interface Computing Final Report

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1 Platform Overview

1.1 Description and Purpose

Kent Date Enough is a college dating web application built specifically for students at Kent State University. Its core purpose is to help students discover romantic or social connections with peers who share their academic life: the same classes, major, year of study, or compatible free periods between lectures.

Unlike general-purpose dating apps, Kent Date Enough integrates directly with the university's Banner course registration system. Users enter their Class Registration Numbers (CRNs) and the app fetches their full course schedule automatically. This schedule data powers a compatibility scoring algorithm that rewards profiles who share classes or overlapping free time, making it far more likely that two matched users will meet organically on campus. Each match also receives an AI-generated icebreaker from the Google Gemini API that references the pair's shared courses, lowering the barrier to a first conversation.

The platform offers the following core functionality:

- **Account creation and authentication**: students create a personal account secured with PBKDF2-HMAC-SHA256 hashed passwords.
- **Profile building**: users fill in name, pronouns, major, year, height, age, a profile photo, and a comma-separated traits section.
- **Schedule integration**: users enter CRNs; the app scrapes Kent State's Banner system (term 202610) and stores full course details.
- **Discover (swipe) interface**: one ranked candidate is shown at a time; the user accepts or rejects them. Arrow-key shortcuts allow rapid browsing.
- **Matching and messaging**: a mutual acceptance creates a match and opens a private chat. Every chat opens with a streamed, AI-generated icebreaker.
- **Notifications**: new matches, unread messages, and profile-completeness nudges are surfaced automatically with a badge counter in the navigation.
- **Settings**: users filter matches by gender preference, age range, and whether major must align.
- **Testimonials**: a public community board for sharing success stories.
- **Reporting**: users can flag inappropriate profiles from the Discover card or the full-profile view.

The application is built with Python (Kindling framework made by TJ), Jinja2 HTML templates, Tailwind CSS for styling, SQLite for data persistence, and the Google Gemini API for icebreaker generation.

2 Pages and Screens

The sections below describe every distinct page in the application. For each page the following are covered:

1. **Purpose**: why the page exists.
2. **Screenshot**: a captured screenshot of the live application.
3. **Golden Rules**: which of Shneiderman's Eight Golden Rules apply and how.
4. **User Interactions**: what the user can do on the page.

2.1 Landing Page (/)

2.1.1 Purpose

The landing page is the first screen unauthenticated visitors see. Its sole job is to communicate what the platform is and to direct the user toward either creating an account or logging into an existing one. It contains no forms and no authenticated content.

2.1.2 Screenshot

Figure 1: Landing page: title, tagline, and the two entry-point buttons.

2.1.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The landing page establishes the full visual language of the application: brand blue, accent yellow, cream card backgrounds, and the Jura display typeface. Every subsequent page inherits this palette and typography, so returning users are immediately oriented regardless of which page they land on.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

The entire decision space fits on one screen: two clearly labelled buttons, "Log In" and "Sign Up". There is nothing to remember, no sub-menu to navigate. The tagline "Find a lover in a flash" communicates the purpose of the platform in a single phrase.

Support Internal Locus of Control

The interface is fully passive until the user acts. Neither button triggers any automatic action; the application waits for the user to choose their path.

2.1.4 User Interactions

- Click **Log In** to navigate to the login page.
- Click **Sign Up** to navigate to account creation.
- No forms, no authentication state, all interactions are simple navigations.

2.2 Sign Up Page (`/signup`)

2.2.1 Purpose

The sign-up page allows a new visitor to create a Kent Date Enough account. It collects a username and password (confirmed twice) and, on success, creates the account along with a default `user_settings` row before presenting a confirmation screen that links to login.

2.2.2 Screenshot

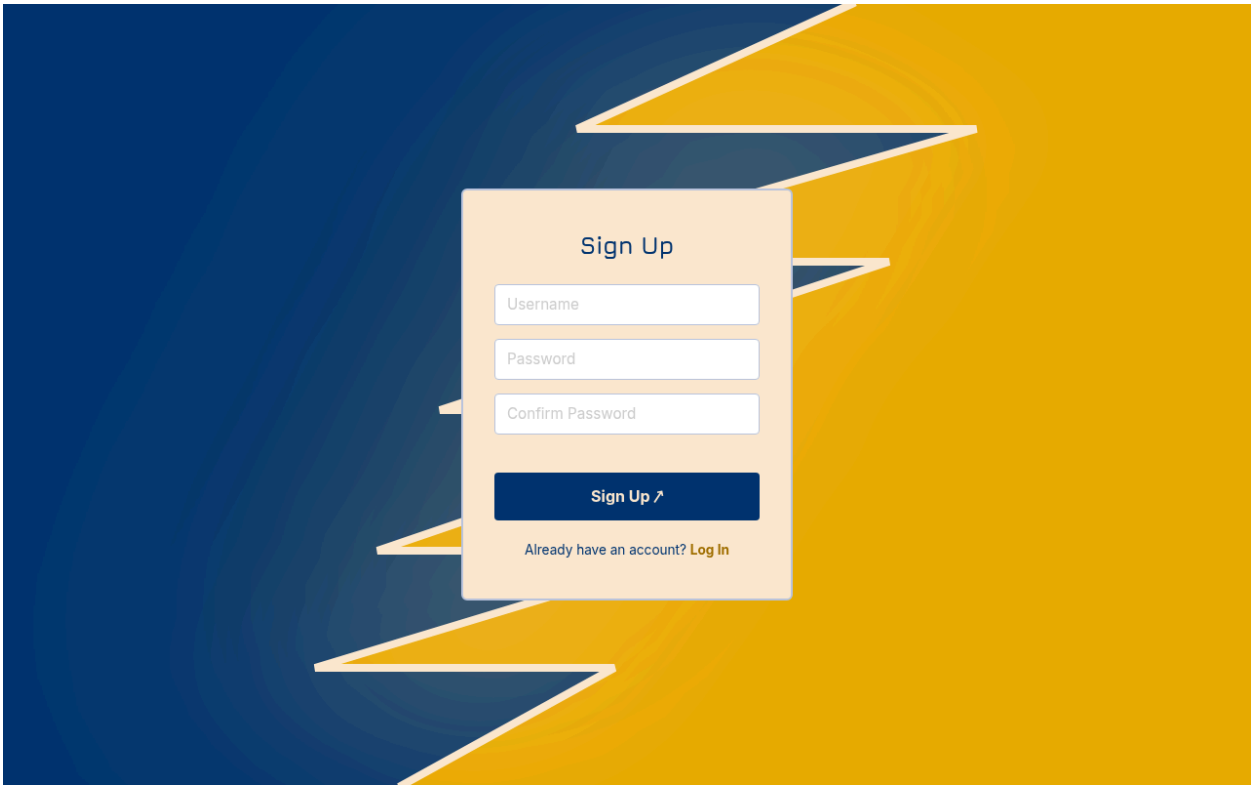

Figure 2: Sign-up page: username, password, and confirm-password fields.

2.2.3 Golden Rules

Offer Informative Feedback

As the user types in the Confirm Password field, the field border changes colour in real time: gold when both passwords match, red when they diverge. This live validation means the user learns of a mismatch immediately, without waiting for a round-trip to the server. Server-side errors (username already taken, password too short) are then displayed inline, directly below the form.

Offer Simple Error Handling

All validation errors appear as plain-English messages. The form retains the username value so only the failing field needs correction. To prevent double-submissions, which would produce confusing duplicate-account errors. The submit button is disabled as soon as the form is submitted and re-enables only if an error is returned.

Design Dialogue to Yield Closure

After a successful creation the page shows a confirmation screen ("Account created! Log in now") so the user knows the three-step flow (fill form → submit → confirm) has reached its natural end before they move on.

Strive for Consistency

The cream card on a slate border, the brand-yellow submit button, and the Jura heading are identical to those on the login page, forming a visual pair that signals these are the two sides of the same authentication gate.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

Password requirements (minimum 6 characters, must match) are enforced through live visual feedback and inline error copy rather than a static notice the user must remember to consult.

2.2.4 User Interactions

- Enter a **username** (must be unique across all accounts).
- Enter a **password** (minimum 6 characters).
- Re-enter the password in **Confirm Password**, the field border updates live to indicate match or mismatch.
- Click **Sign Up** (or press Enter) to submit.
- On success: a confirmation screen appears with a link to the login page.
- On failure: inline error messages describe the problem; correct and resubmit.

2.3 Login Page (`/login`)

2.3.1 Purpose

The login page authenticates returning users. It verifies the submitted username and password against the stored PBKDF2-HMAC-SHA256 hash and, on success, creates a session cookie and redirects to the Discover page.

2.3.2 Screenshot

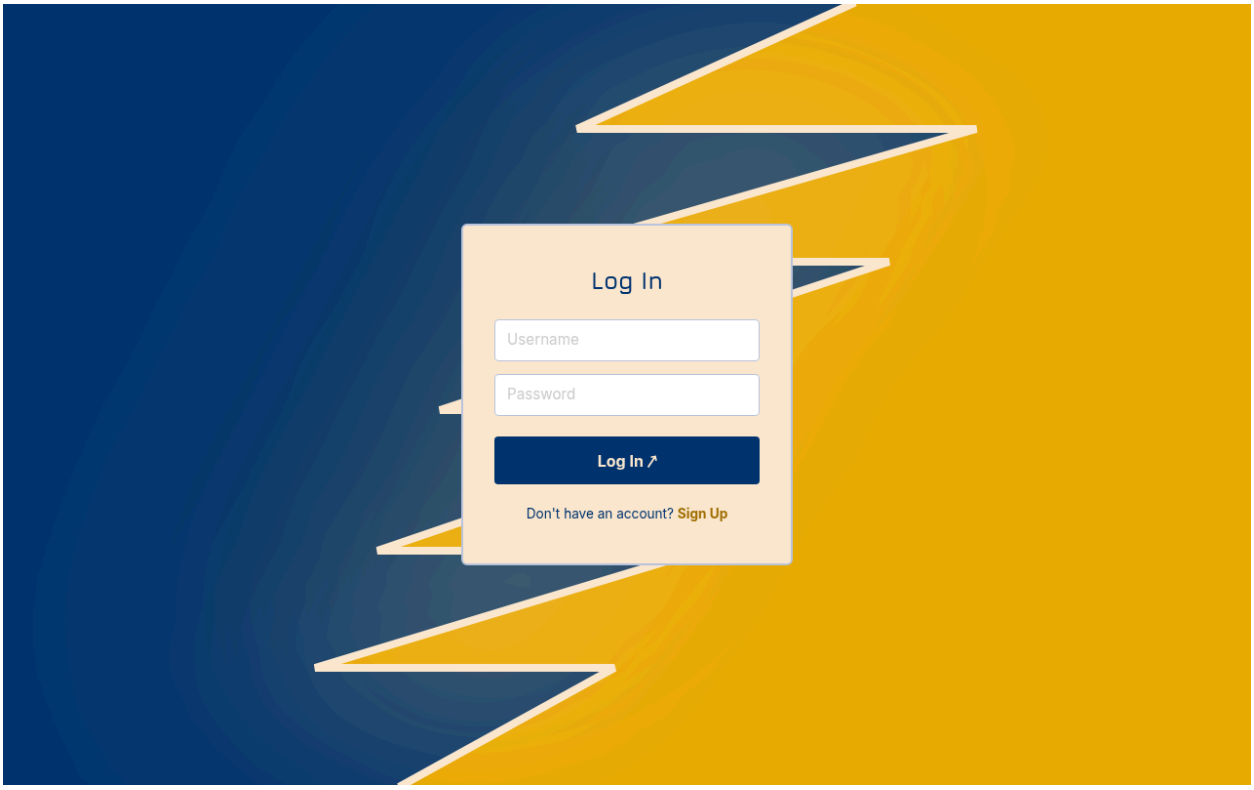

Figure 3: Login page: username and password fields, Log In button, and sign-up link.

2.3.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The card layout, colour scheme, and button style are identical to the sign-up page. The two screens are visually paired, making it obvious they belong to the same authentication flow.

Offer Informative Feedback

Incorrect credentials produce a clear error message ("Invalid username or password") displayed at the top of the card. The user is never left wondering whether the problem was the username, the password, or the server.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

A "Don't have an account? Sign up" link at the bottom of the card lets users who arrived at the wrong page recover without resorting to the browser's Back button.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

Only two fields are required. Placeholder text reminds the user of what each field expects. There are no CAPTCHA challenges or secondary factors that the user must remember how to complete.

2.3.4 User Interactions

- Enter **username** and **password**.
- Click **Log In** (or press Enter) to authenticate.
- On success: redirected to `/discover`.
- On failure: inline error message; try again.
- Click **Sign up here** to navigate to account creation.

2.4 My Profile Page (`/profile`)

2.4.1 Purpose

The profile page lets authenticated users build and edit their personal profile: photo, name, pronouns, gender, major, year, height, age, and a comma-separated traits section. This information appears on every profile card shown to other users in the Discover feed and drives the compatibility scoring algorithm, users with more complete profiles surface higher in other users' feeds.

2.4.2 Screenshot

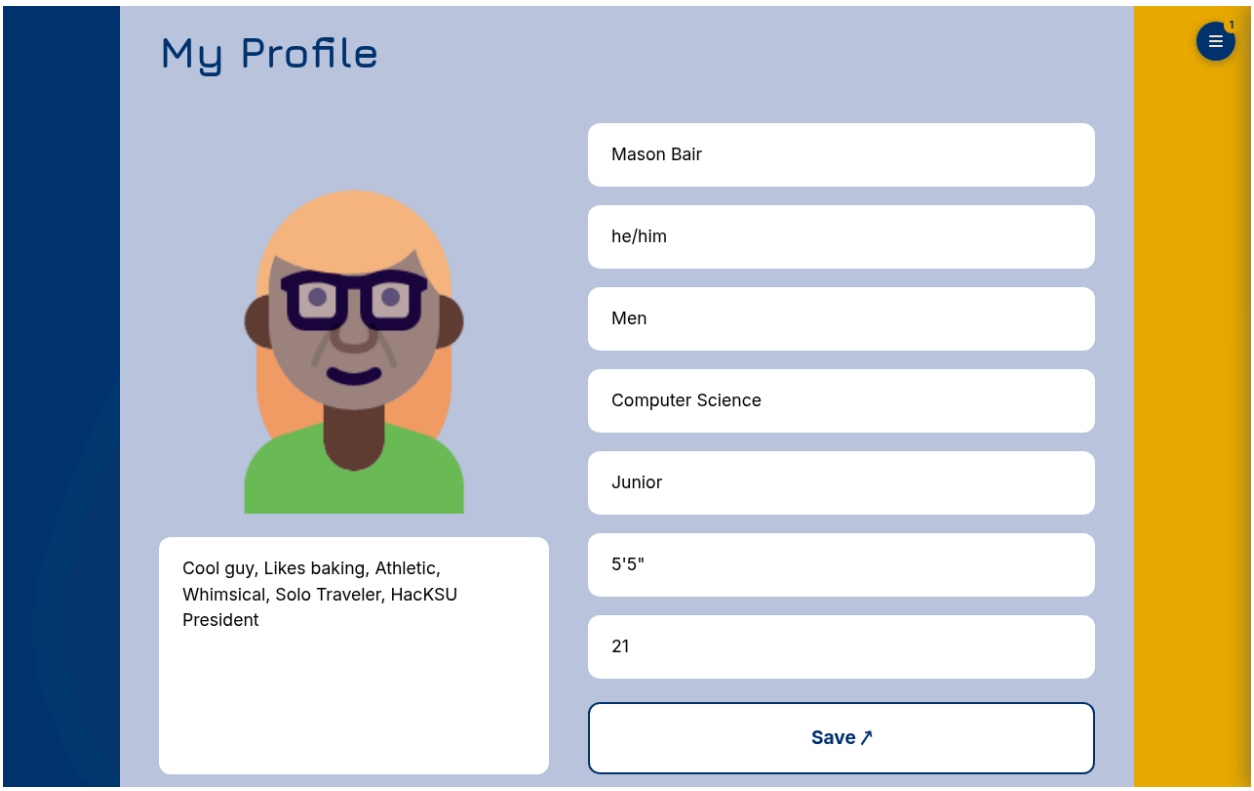

Figure 4: My Profile: photo upload on the left, editable fields on the right.

2.4.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The two-column layout (photo left, fields right) mirrors the visual structure of the Settings and Chats pages. Dropdowns for Gender and Year use the same `<select>` styling as every other dropdown in the application.

Offer Informative Feedback

Selecting a new photo triggers an immediate live preview in the circular photo area, no submit required. After saving, a toast notification appears prominently above the form reading "Profile updated!", confirming the action. This toast placement was deliberately chosen to ensure it is visible without scrolling.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

The page tracks a "dirty" state whenever a field value changes. If the user tries to navigate away before saving, a browser confirmation dialog warns that unsaved changes will be discarded. This guards against accidental data loss from clicking a sidebar link mid-edit.

Offer Simple Error Handling

Required fields (Name, Age) are enforced before submission with inline error messages. Age is validated to be 18 or older. The Major field uses a `<datalist>` populated with 40+ Kent State programmes, and Height uses a datalist spanning 4′10″ to 6′5″, both normalising free-text input so that matching and display remain consistent.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

Autocomplete suggestions for Major and Height mean users do not need to recall a specific format string. The photo preview area displays the current photo whenever the page loads, so users always know what others will see.

2.4.4 User Interactions

- Click the **photo area** to open the file picker; the preview updates immediately on selection.
- Fill in **Name** and **Age** (required fields).
- Optionally fill in **Pronouns**, **Major** (autocomplete), **Year** (dropdown), **Height** (datalist), **Gender** (dropdown), and **Traits** (comma-separated).
- Click **Save** to persist changes; a success toast confirms the update.
- Navigating away with unsaved changes triggers a "discard changes?" dialog.

2.5 Discover Page (`/discover`)

2.5.1 Purpose

The Discover page is the primary matching interface. One candidate profile is shown at a time, ranked by a composite compatibility score, and the user accepts or rejects the candidate. When two users have each accepted the other a match is created and chat becomes available. The page

intentionally presents one profile at a time to focus the user's attention and prevent decision paralysis.

2.5.2 Screenshot

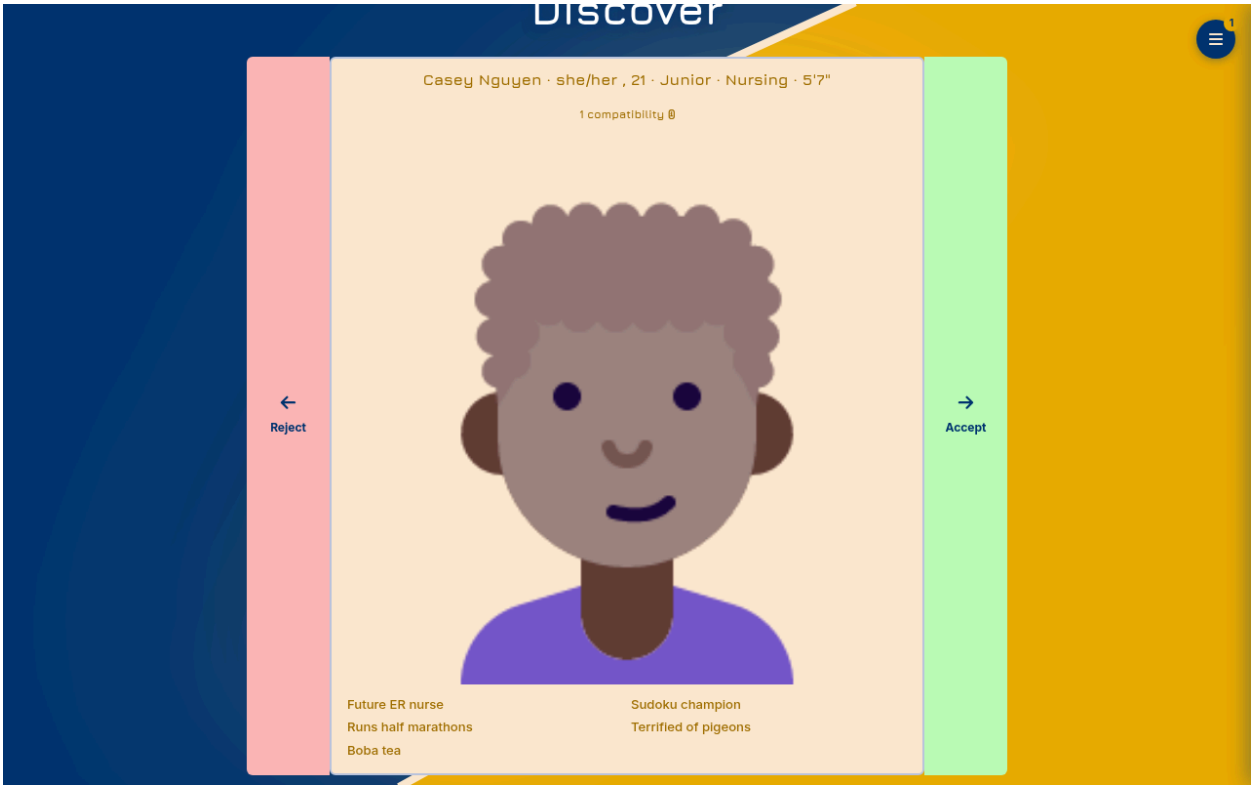

Figure 5: Discover: ranked profile card with compatibility badge, Accept and Reject buttons.

2.5.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The Accept button is always green and positioned on the right; the Reject button is always red and on the left. This spatial-colour convention never changes across profiles, allowing users to build a reliable motor habit and act quickly without reading button labels on each card. All other destructive or irreversible actions in the application also use red buttons, reinforcing the same convention globally.

Enable Frequent Users to Use Shortcuts

Arrow-key bindings were added explicitly for power users: the **right arrow** accepts and the **left arrow** rejects. Users who swipe through many profiles per session can do so entirely from the keyboard with no mouse interaction required.

Offer Informative Feedback

- A numeric compatibility score badge on each card shows how well the candidate aligns with the current user. Hovering the badge reveals a tooltip that breaks down the score components: shared CRNs, same major, same year, and overlapping free periods.
- A match toast ("It's a match with [Name]!") appears at the top of the page immediately after a mutual acceptance.
- An "Undo" notification bar appears at the bottom after each rejection, confirming the swipe was registered and offering a way to reverse it.
- When all available candidates have been swiped, a "No more profiles" message replaces the card so the user is never left staring at an empty page.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

The Undo bar remains visible for several seconds after a rejection. Clicking it POSTs to `/discover/undo`, which deletes the swipe record and reloads the same profile so the user can reconsider. Only the most recent swipe can be undone, which keeps the undo semantics simple and predictable.

Support Internal Locus of Control

Yellow nudge banners appear when the user's profile is missing key fields or their schedule is empty. These are informational only, they link to the Profile and Schedule pages but do not block swiping or force any action. The user decides when and whether to act on them.

Offer Simple Error Handling

The report flow is hidden behind a secondary affordance: clicking "Report" expands a form with an optional reason field (max 300 characters) and a confirmation submit. This two-step design prevents accidental reports. The server also filters out the current user's own profile, ensuring users can never accidentally see or swipe themselves.

2.5.4 User Interactions

- **Accept** a profile: click the green Accept button or press the right arrow key. A swipe record is created; if the other user has also accepted, a match is formed and a toast confirms it.
- **Reject** a profile: click the red Reject button or press the left arrow key. An Undo bar appears at the bottom of the screen.
- **Undo** a rejection: click the Undo bar to delete the swipe and revisit the same profile.
- **View compatibility breakdown**: hover the score badge to see a tooltip listing what contributed to the score.
- **Act on nudges**: click links in yellow banners to navigate to Profile or Schedule.
- **Report** a user: click "Report", optionally enter a reason, and submit.

2.6 Chats Page (`/chats`)

2.6.1 Purpose

The Chats page is the messaging hub. A left sidebar lists all current matches with their photos and names; the right pane shows the active conversation. Each conversation opens with an AI-generated icebreaker personalised to the two users' shared classes and profile traits, streamed in real time from the Google Gemini API.

2.6.2 Screenshot

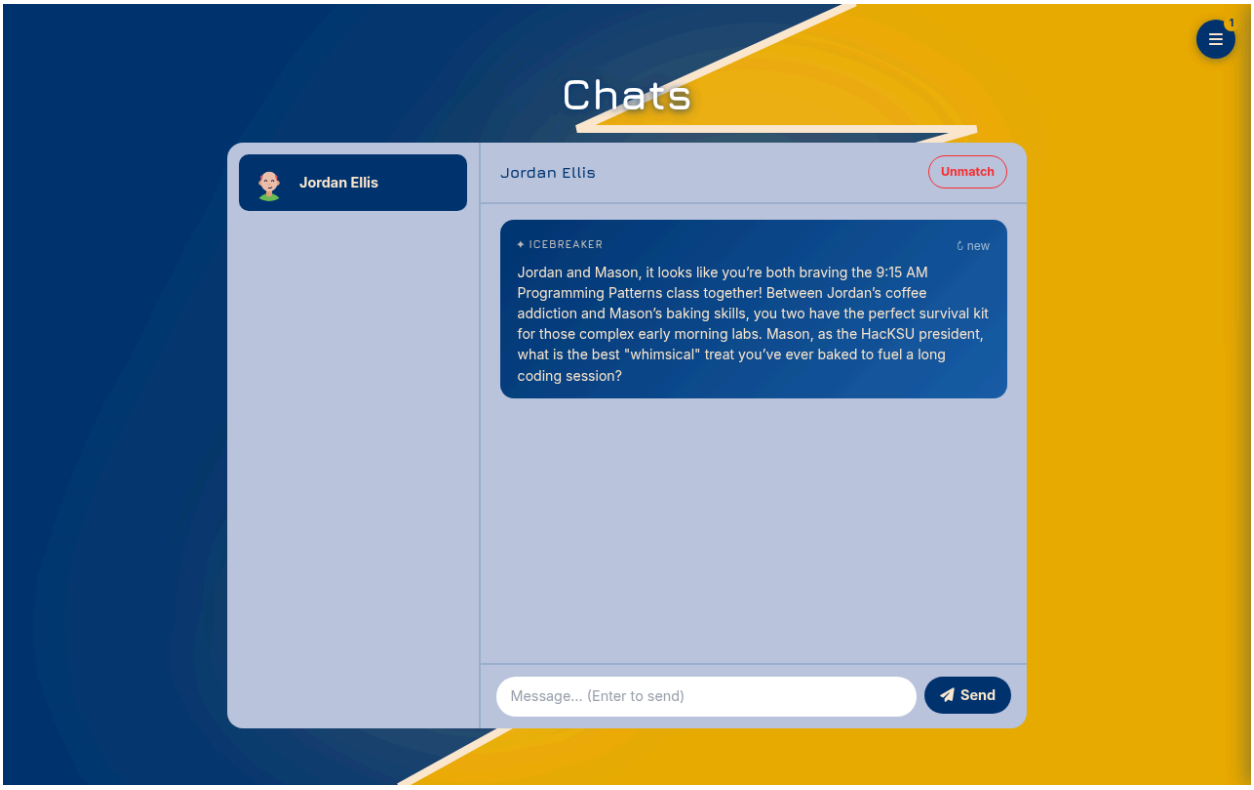

Figure 6: Chats: match list on the left, active conversation with icebreaker on the right.

2.6.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

Sent messages are always right-aligned with a brand-blue background; received messages are left-aligned on a white background. This directional colour convention is consistent across every conversation and mirrors the established convention of consumer messaging applications, minimising the learning curve. Timestamps are shown beneath each message, displayed in the same position and style throughout.

Enable Frequent Users to Use Shortcuts

Pressing **Enter** in the message input sends the message, matching the universal shortcut expected in every modern chat interface. Users who exchange many messages per session never need to reach for the Send button.

Offer Informative Feedback

- While the Gemini API streams the icebreaker text, a shimmer (skeleton-loader) animation fills the icebreaker card so the user knows content is loading rather than assuming the feature is broken. If the SSE stream fails, an explicit error message replaces the shimmer, the user is never left staring at an infinite animation.
- The conversation pane auto-scrolls to the newest message on open and on each new send, keeping the latest content in view without manual scrolling.
- The match-count label in the sidebar header tells users at a glance how many active matches they have.

Design Dialogue to Yield Closure

Unmatching requires a two-step confirmation dialog ("Are you sure you want to unmatch [Name]?"). This deliberate friction prevents accidental deletion of a conversation and gives the user a clear, intentional exit point.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

If the first AI-generated icebreaker is unsuitable, the user can click the **↻ new** button to request a fresh one from the Gemini API. The regeneration is non-destructive: previous messages in the conversation are unaffected.

Support Internal Locus of Control

Every action in the Chats page is user-initiated: opening a conversation, sending a message, regenerating an icebreaker, and unmatching. The interface does not push content or navigate automatically after any of these actions.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

Each entry in the match sidebar displays the user's profile photo and display name rather than just a username, so users do not need to map cryptic usernames to remembered faces.

2.6.4 User Interactions

- Click a **match name or photo** in the sidebar to open that conversation.
- Read the **icebreaker card** at the top of the conversation; if it is still loading, a shimmer animation indicates progress.
- Click **↻ new** to discard the current icebreaker and generate a fresh one.
- Type a message and press **Enter** or click the paper-plane **Send** button.
- Click a match's **name** in the conversation header to navigate to their full profile view.

- Click **Unmatch** and confirm the dialog to end the match and remove the conversation.

2.7 My Schedule Page (`/schedule`)

2.7.1 Purpose

The Schedule page lets users build a personal course schedule by entering Kent State CRNs. The stored schedule serves two functions: it increases the compatibility score with classmates in the Discover feed (shared CRNs are worth the most points in the algorithm), and it supplies course context to the Gemini API when generating icebreakers.

2.7.2 Screenshot

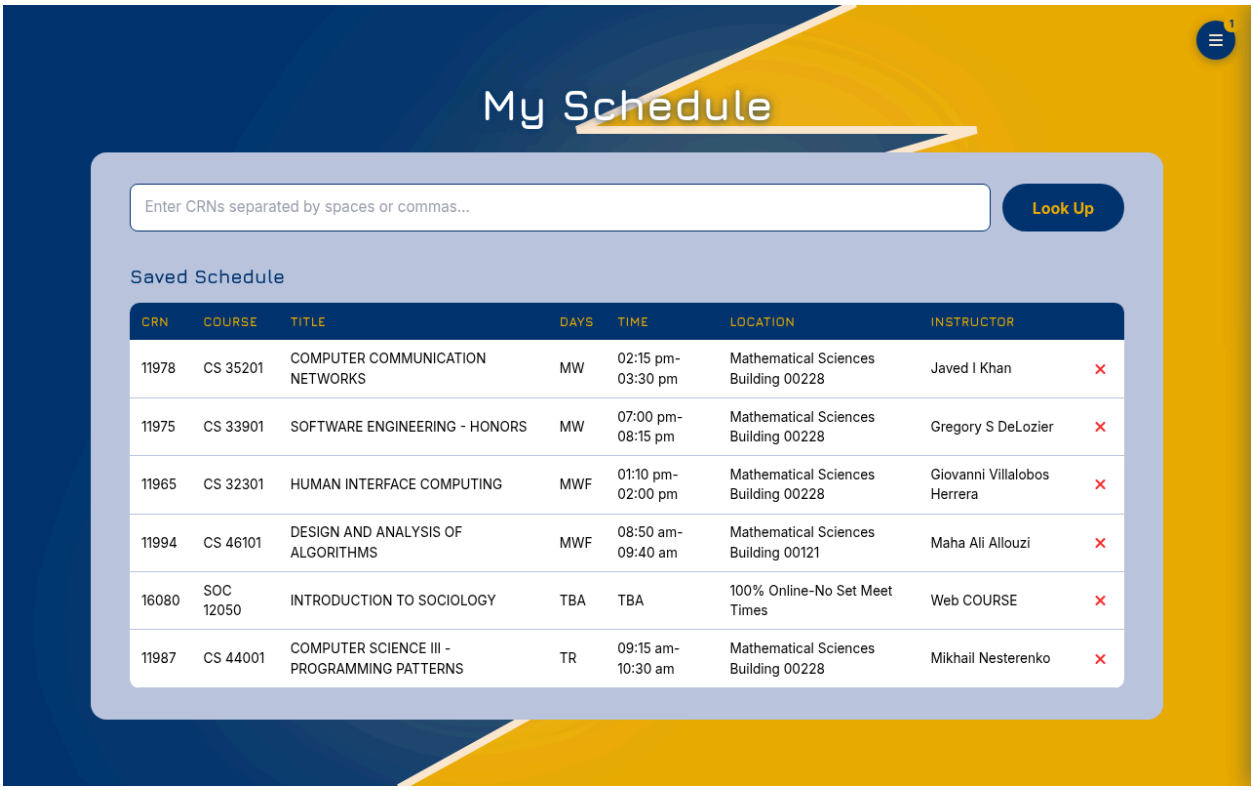

Figure 7: My Schedule: CRN lookup input, preview table, and saved schedule table.

2.7.3 Golden Rules

Design Dialogue to Yield Closure

Adding courses follows a deliberate two-step flow. First the user enters CRNs and clicks **Look Up**, the server scrapes Kent State's Banner system and returns a preview table showing CRN, course code, title, days, time, location, and instructor. Only after reviewing this preview does the user click **Add to My Schedule** to commit the data. This review step is the closure point: the user confirms what will be saved before it is saved.

Offer Informative Feedback

- The preview table gives full course details before any changes are committed, so the user can verify they entered the correct CRNs.
- CRNs that could not be resolved in the Banner system are listed explicitly below the table ("The following CRNs were not found: …"), distinguishing scraping failures from valid additions.
- After removing a course, a toast notification confirms the deletion and presents an Undo button.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

Each saved course row includes a delete (×) button. After deletion the Undo toast remains visible long enough for the user to restore the course if they acted by mistake.

Offer Simple Error Handling

If a batch of CRNs is looked up and some are invalid, only the failed CRNs are flagged, valid ones still appear in the preview and can be added normally. The user corrects only what failed, not the entire input.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

By entering only a CRN, the user retrieves all associated course data automatically. There is no need to manually type course names, building codes, instructor names, or meeting times, eliminating transcription errors and the cognitive burden of cross-referencing a separate schedule document.

2.7.4 User Interactions

- Enter one or more **CRNs** (comma- or space-separated) and click **Look Up**.
- Review the **preview table**; check which CRNs could not be found.
- Click **Add to My Schedule** to save the previewed courses to the database.
- Click the × **button** on a saved row to remove a course.
- Click **Undo** in the toast to restore the most recently removed course.

2.8 Settings Page (`/settings`)

2.8.1 Purpose

The Settings page is divided into two cards: **Match With?** controls who appears in the Discover feed (gender, age range, major overlap), and **Account Information** provides access to password reset and account deletion. Together they give users full control over their matching preferences and account lifecycle.

2.8.2 Screenshot

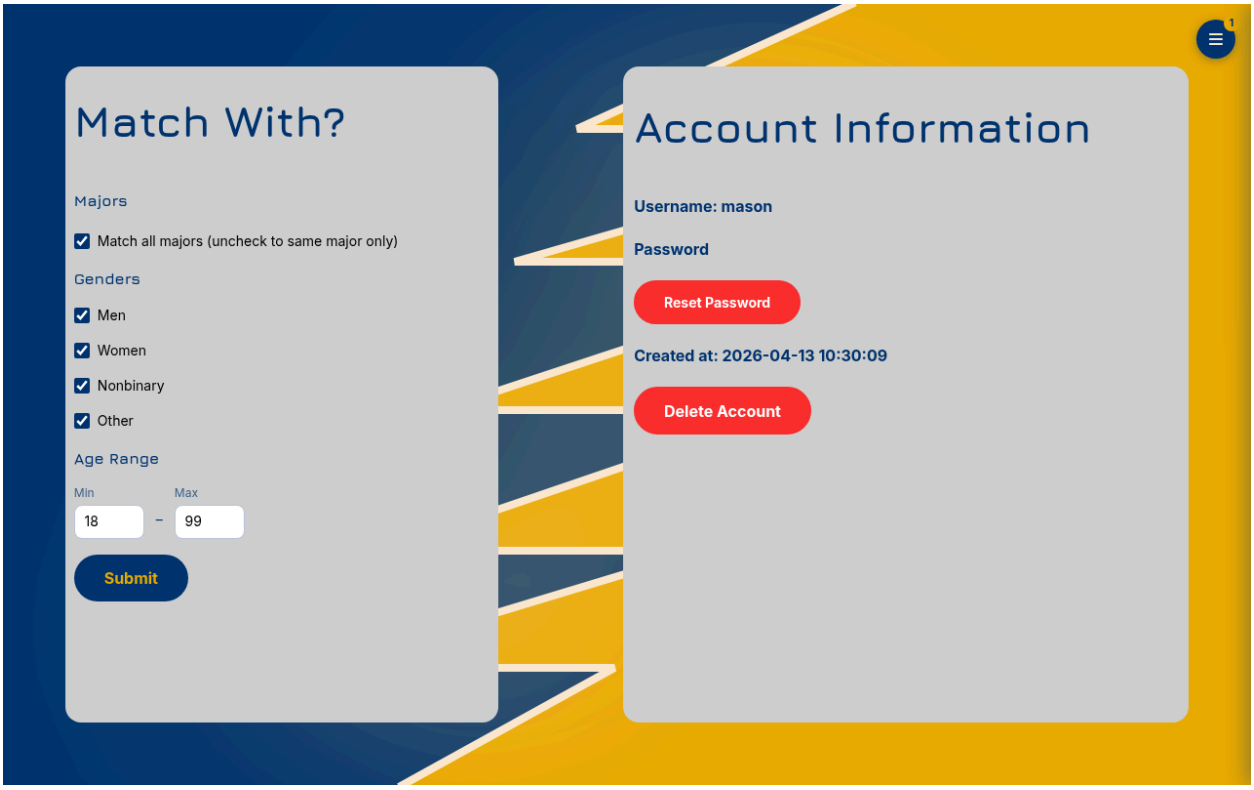

Figure 8: Settings: Match With? preferences on the left, Account Information on the right.

2.8.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The two-column card layout and button styling match the Profile page. All destructive actions (Delete Account) use a red button, consistent with every other irreversible action in the application.

Offer Informative Feedback

After saving preferences, a success message ("Settings saved!") appears at the top of the Match With? card. Client-side validation fires immediately if all gender checkboxes are deselected and the user tries to save, an inline error message appears before any network request is made, so the round-trip is skipped entirely.

Offer Simple Error Handling

The only hard validation rule is that at least one gender must be checked. The error message names the exact problem; the age range and major preference inputs are unaffected and retain their values. No data is lost when validation fails.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

- Clicking **Reset Password** navigates to a dedicated page where no change happens until the user completes and submits the new-password form. Navigating back from that page leaves the existing password intact.
- The **Delete Account** button triggers a confirmation dialog requiring explicit acknowledgement before any irreversible data deletion occurs.

Support Internal Locus of Control

Default values cover all genders, all majors, and the full age range (18–99), so a user who does not want to customise anything can ignore this page entirely. Every preference is an intentional opt-in or opt-out.

2.8.4 User Interactions

- Toggle **Match all majors** to restrict or open major overlap.
- Check or uncheck gender checkboxes (**Men, Women, Nonbinary, Other**).
- Adjust **Min Age** and **Max Age** number inputs (18–99).
- Click **Save Preferences**; a success banner confirms persistence.
- Click **Reset Password** to begin the password-change flow.
- Click **Delete Account** and confirm the dialog to permanently remove all account data.

2.9 Reset Password Page (`/reset-password`)

2.9.1 Purpose

The Reset Password page allows an authenticated user to change their account password. It mirrors the sign-up page's password-confirmation pattern to keep the mental model consistent for users who have already learned that flow.

2.9.2 Screenshot

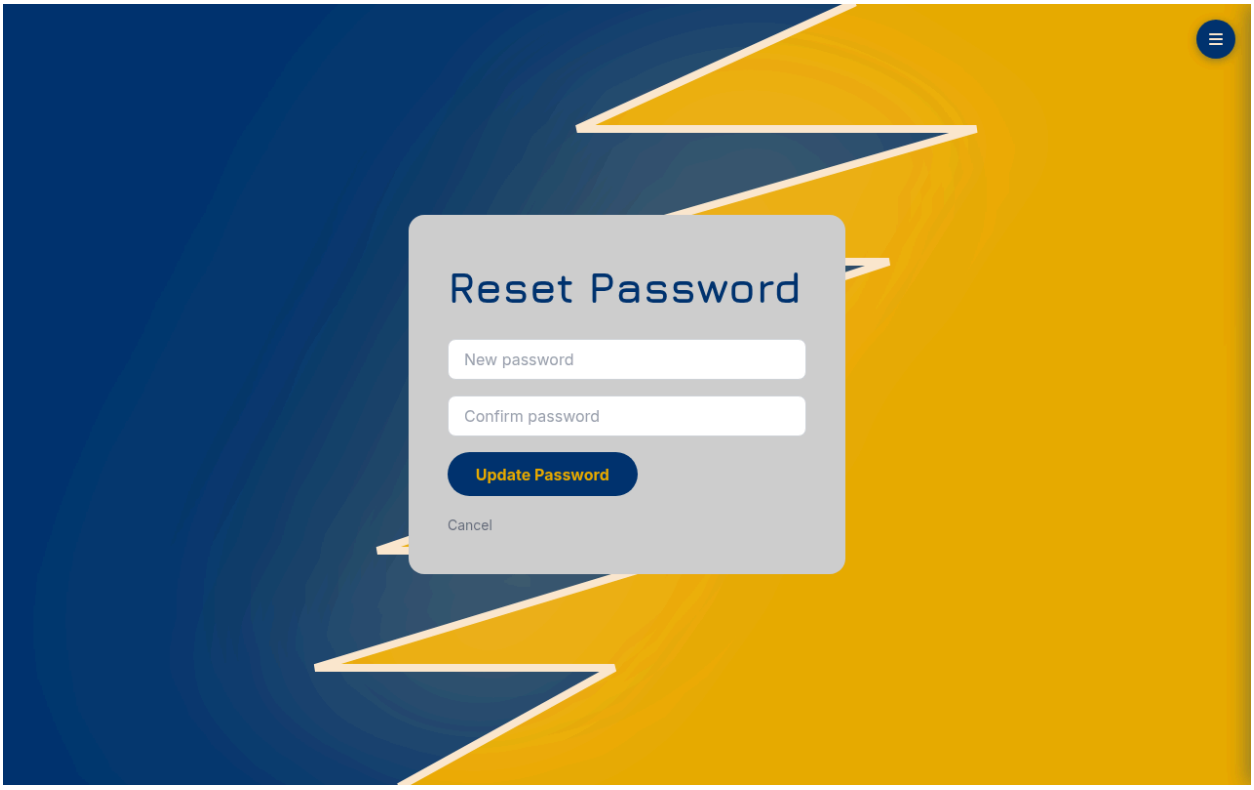

Figure 9: Reset Password: new password and confirm-password fields, with Cancel link.

2.9.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The form layout, card style, and validation feedback (inline errors, field border colour changes) are identical to those used at sign-up. A returning user who has forgotten the password rules does not need to look them up, the same conventions apply.

Offer Informative Feedback

Server-side validation errors (passwords do not match, too short) are shown as inline messages without a page reload. On success, a confirmation message appears briefly before the user is redirected back to Settings.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

A **Cancel** link returns the user to Settings without making any change. The existing password remains active until the user explicitly submits a valid new one.

Offer Simple Error Handling

Validation rules (minimum 6 characters, fields must match) are the same as at sign-up, so users who have been through account creation already know them. Error messages are specific rather than generic ("Passwords must match" is distinct from "Password must be at least 6 characters").

2.9.4 User Interactions

- Enter **New Password** and **Confirm Password**.
- Click **Update Password** to submit.
- On success: confirmation message, then automatic redirect to Settings.
- On failure: inline error message; correct the relevant field and resubmit.
- Click **Cancel** to return to Settings without any change.

2.10 Notifications Page (`/notifications`)

2.10.1 Purpose

The Notifications page aggregates all actionable alerts into a single location: new matches, unread message counts, and prompts to complete an incomplete profile or add a schedule. A numeric badge in the navigation sidebar reflects the count at all times, so users know whether to visit this page before they open it.

2.10.2 Screenshot

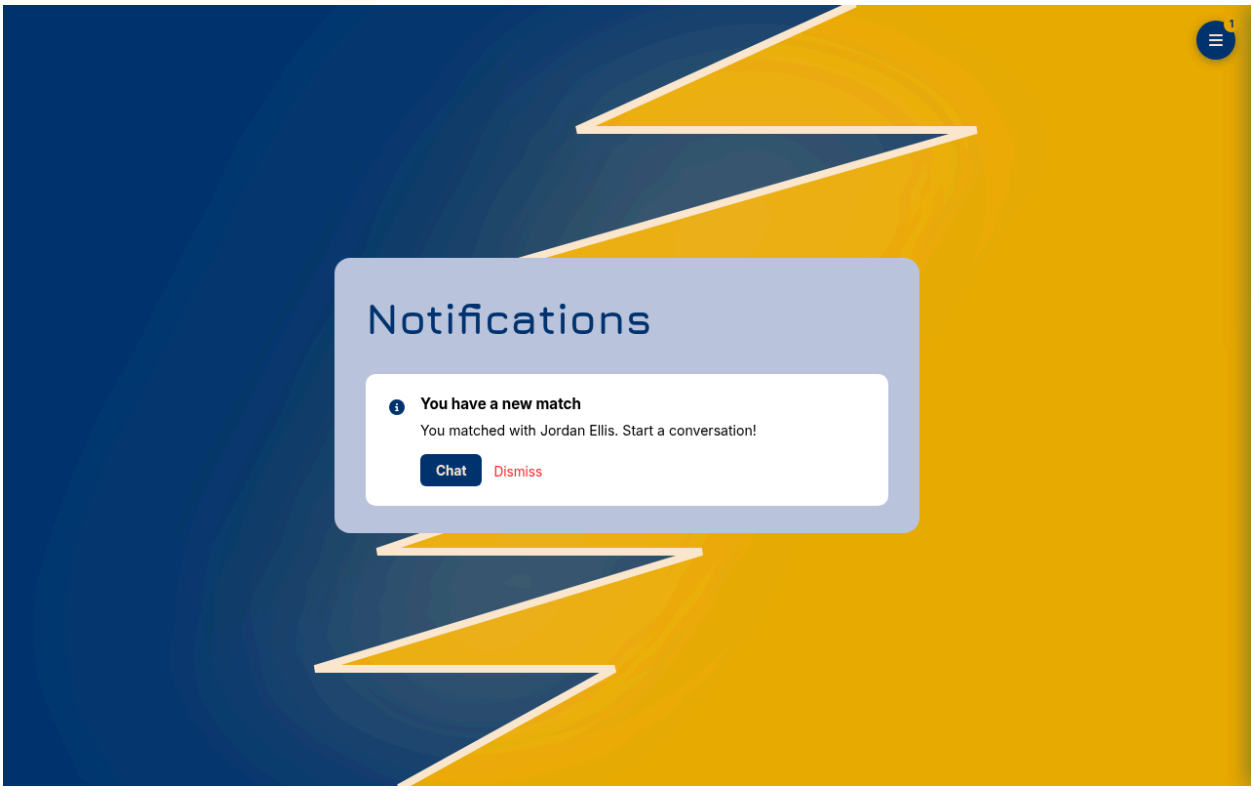

Figure 10: Notifications: cards for new matches, unread messages, and profile nudges.

2.10.3 Golden Rules

Offer Informative Feedback

Every notification card uses a distinct icon and plain-language description: "You matched with Jordan", "Riley sent you 3 unread messages", "Complete your profile with name, age, and photo". The user understands what happened and what to do next without opening any other page. The sidebar badge provides persistent feedback across the entire application.

Design Dialogue to Yield Closure

Each notification type has one primary action button that resolves the notification: "Chat" opens the relevant conversation, "Open Chat" navigates directly to unread messages, "Update Profile" links to the profile editor, and "Add Schedule" links to the schedule page. Clicking the action button is the natural endpoint of the notification's lifecycle.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

Match notification cards have a **Dismiss** button that sends a POST to `/notifications/dismiss` and removes the card. If a user accidentally dismisses a notification, they can still navigate to Chats to find the match, dismissal only removes the card, not the match itself.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

Instead of requiring users to remember they received a match and then navigate to Chats, the notification system surfaces this context proactively. The badge counter makes it possible to assess notification status at a glance from any page.

Support Internal Locus of Control

Profile-completeness and schedule nudges are advisory, not blocking. The user can ignore them indefinitely and continue using Discover and Chats without completing their profile. The nudges reappear only because the underlying condition has not changed, not because the system is nagging them.

2.10.4 User Interactions

- Browse all active notification cards.
- Click **Chat** on a match notification to open the new match's conversation.
- Click **Dismiss** to remove a match notification (the match is preserved).
- Click **Open Chat** on an unread-message notification to go directly to that conversation.
- Click **Update Profile** or **Add Schedule** to navigate to the relevant page.
- The badge count in the sidebar updates to reflect the current number of active notifications.

2.11 Testimonials Page (`/testimonials`)

2.11.1 Purpose

The Testimonials page is a community board where users can post short success stories or endorsements of the platform (up to 300 characters). It provides social proof for new users and a sense of community for existing ones. Each user may have at most one active testimonial, which they can edit or delete at any time.

2.11.2 Screenshot

Figure 11: Testimonials: submission textarea with character counter and the community grid.

2.11.3 Golden Rules

Offer Informative Feedback

A live character counter ("0 / 300") updates on every keystroke so users always know how much space remains. The counter turns visually distinct as the limit approaches, preventing surprise truncation.

Design Dialogue to Yield Closure

The submit button's label is context-sensitive: it reads "Share" when the user has no existing testimonial and "Update" when one already exists. This label change signals which action will

occur before the button is clicked. After submission, the updated testimonial appears immediately in the grid below, confirming the save without a separate success message.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

If a user has submitted a testimonial, a **Delete** button appears alongside "Update". The user can remove their own testimonial at any time, there is no waiting period or approval flow.

Reduce Short-Term Memory Load

When a user returns to the page after a prior submission, the textarea is pre-populated with their existing testimonial text. They do not need to remember what they wrote previously to edit it; they simply modify the pre-filled content.

2.11.4 User Interactions

- Type a testimonial (up to 300 characters); the live counter updates.
- Click **Share** to publish a new testimonial.
- Click **Update** to replace an existing testimonial.
- Click **Delete** to remove an existing testimonial entirely.
- Browse the **testimonial grid** to read other users' posts; posts are displayed with the author's profile photo and name.

2.12 Profile View Page (`/profile/<id>`)

2.12.1 Purpose

The Profile View page presents the full profile of another user. It is reached by clicking a match's name from within the Chats page. It exists because the Discover card deliberately shows a condensed view; once matched and chatting, both users benefit from seeing each other's complete information. The page is access-controlled: only matched users may view each other's profile this way.

2.12.2 Screenshot

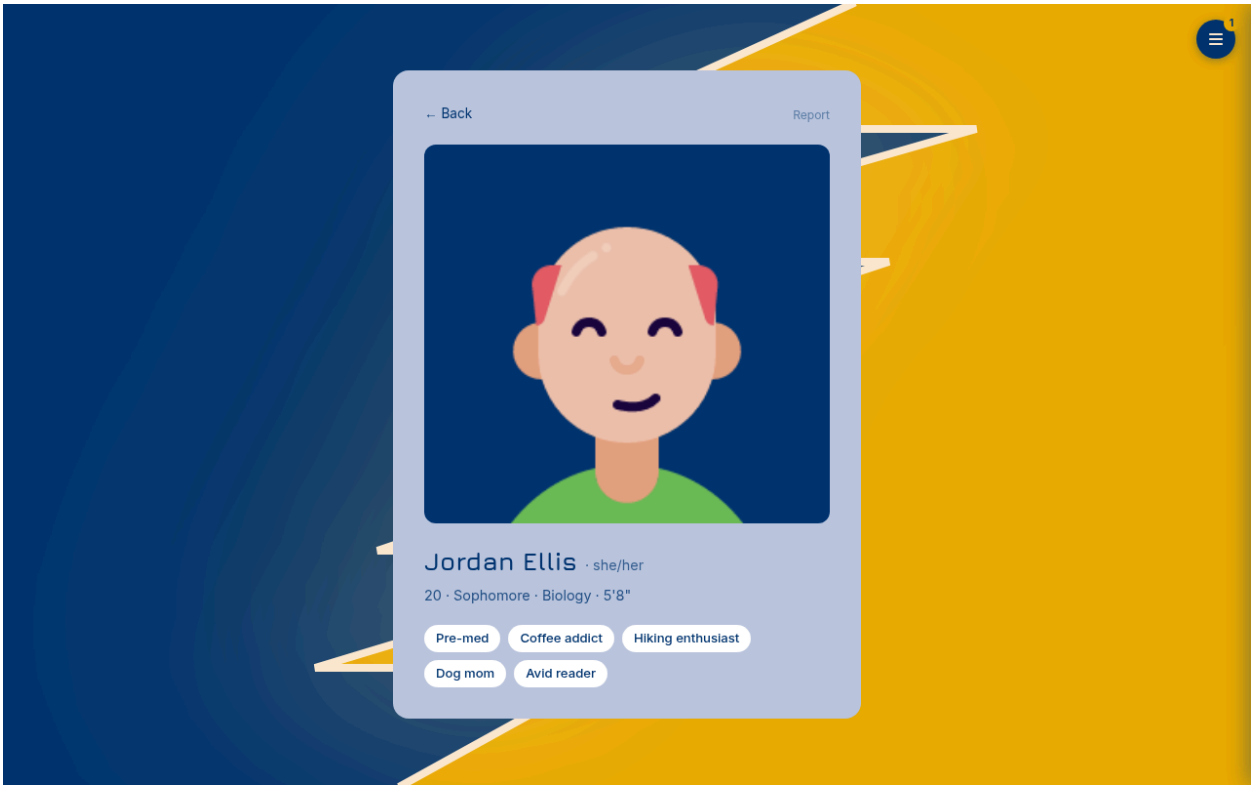

Figure 12: Profile View: photo, header details, traits pills, and report option.

2.12.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The layout, profile photo, header row with name, pronouns, age, major, year, and height, followed by traits displayed as rounded badge pills, exactly mirrors the card shown in the Discover feed. The user builds a single mental model for how a person is represented and encounters it consistently across both contexts.

Support Internal Locus of Control

The user arrived here voluntarily by clicking a match's name in Chats. A Back button at the top of the page returns them to the same conversation without disrupting scroll position or message state. Navigation is always user-driven.

Offer Simple Error Handling

Access is enforced server-side: if an unauthenticated user or a non-matched user attempts to reach this URL directly, the server rejects the request. Legitimate matched users always have seamless access; unauthorised access is blocked without a confusing error page, they are simply redirected.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

The Report option is hidden behind a secondary interaction: clicking "Report" expands an inline form with an optional reason text field and a confirmation submit button. The two-step flow prevents accidental reports while keeping the option discoverable for users who need it.

2.12.4 User Interactions

- Click the **Back arrow** to return to the Chats page.
- View the full profile: photo, name, pronouns, age, year, major, height, and traits.
- Click **Report** to expand the report form, optionally enter a reason (max 300 characters), and submit.

2.13 Navigation Sidebar (Global)

2.13.1 Purpose

A slide-out navigation sidebar is available from every authenticated page via a hamburger button in the top-right corner. It provides access to all seven major sections of the application, shows the current notification count, and contains the logout action. Because the same sidebar appears on every page, it functions as the application's primary navigation layer.

2.13.2 Screenshot

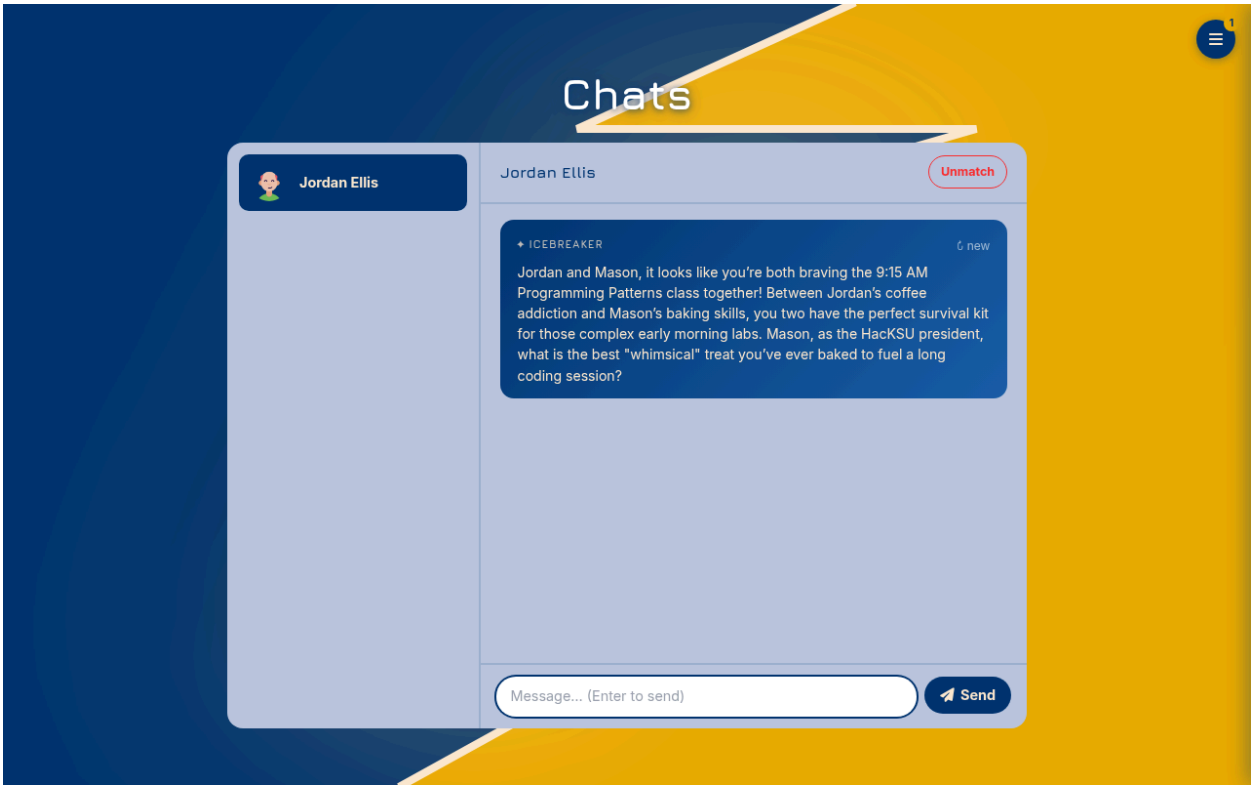

Figure 13: Navigation sidebar: links with icons, notification badge on the bell, and the Logout button.

2.13.3 Golden Rules

Strive for Consistency

The hamburger button occupies the same top-right position on every page. The sidebar always lists the same seven links in the same order with the same icons. After even a short session, users can navigate by muscle memory without reading labels.

Enable Frequent Users to Use Shortcuts

The **Escape key** closes the sidebar immediately. Clicking any navigation link navigates instantly without a confirmation step. These two keyboard behaviours allow frequent users to open and dismiss the sidebar without reaching for the mouse.

Offer Informative Feedback

The notification bell icon carries a live numeric badge showing the count of unread notifications. This badge is rendered on every authenticated page so the user always knows their notification status at a glance, without needing to visit the Notifications page.

Permit Easy Reversal of Actions

Three separate mechanisms close the sidebar without navigating: the × button inside the sidebar, pressing Escape, or clicking the semi-transparent overlay behind the sidebar. The user can open and close it as many times as needed with minimal friction.

Design Dialogue to Yield Closure

The **Log Out** action requires a confirmation dialog before the session is ended. This prevents accidental logouts, particularly important on shared devices, and gives the user a clear, intentional endpoint to the session lifecycle.

2.13.4 User Interactions

- Click the **hamburger icon** (☰) to open the sidebar.
- Click any nav link (Discover, My Profile, Chats, Notifications, Schedule, Testimonials, Settings) to navigate.
- Close the sidebar by clicking the × **button**, clicking the **overlay**, or pressing **Escape**.
- Click **Log Out** and confirm the dialog to end the session.